

Lost in Translation: Researchers' Reflections on Writing in English for CHI

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Abstract

What would linguistic diversity and inclusion look like for Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) research and researchers? As neurotypical and neurodiverse non-native- and native-English researchers, we conduct research in a variety of languages and contexts with diverse user groups and communities, and face several challenges when that research is written, read, reviewed, and published in English. In this paper, we present our first-person reflections on writing for research in English. We have two main goals: (1) to showcase the rich linguistic diversity of HCI research and researchers, and (2) to document challenges of translating socio-culturally nuanced findings and insights into English from other languages. This paper presents our vision of linguistic diversity and inclusion in HCI research at CHI - a mélange of thoughts utilizing diverse vocabularies and languages.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → Human computer interaction (HCI).

Keywords

Diversity, Inclusion, Writing for Research

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1 Introduction

"Do you know how frustrating it is to translate everything in my head before I say it? Do you even know how smart I am in Spanish?" (Gloria Pritchett, Season 6, episode 7, Modern Family).

Diversity and inclusion are extremely important, not just for the research we do, but also for CHI as a community. But what does it mean to be diverse and inclusive in terms of expressions and language? In this paper, we explore diversity and inclusion in Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) research and with researchers

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within the context of academic writing. We wonder out loud – *how can CHI be diverse and inclusive for research conducted in non-English languages and contexts and with non-native English communities and users?* While this question is not new, nor only relevant to HCI (see e.g., [1] [8]); it is more crucial than ever to critically examine our reliance on academic English given the increasing use of LLMs for academic writing, which exacerbates the issues of diversity and inclusion. Studies show that LLM detectors unfairly discriminate against non-native English speakers [10] [11]. LLM also unfairly disadvantage non-native English speakers, for instance, when writing collaboratively non-native English speakers might spend more time and effort in assessing LLM outputs than native English speakers [13]. On the other hand, the increasing use of generative AI “not only limits information access for non-native English speakers but also risks fostering a monocultural AI primarily proficient in English, neglecting other languages and cultures” [12]. Sharing first-person reflections about our experiences in writing for research, we present our vision of diversity and inclusion in HCI research at CHI - a *mélange* of thoughts that utilize various vocabularies, which we sometimes struggle to translate to English. We also discuss possible pathways forward.

Our approach connects to previous work on decolonizing HCI that shares authors’ first-person perspectives (e.g., [4] [7]) and the growing use of first-person methods in HCI ([3] [6]). In our process, the first author invited each co-author to respond to a set of prompts (listed in Appendix A) reflecting on their experiences with translation between their native language and English in their research and writing process. Then, the first author collected these responses and surfaced emergent themes. We present these themes in the next section together with researchers’ reflections (in blue text), followed by authors’ positionality to situate their reflections within their cultural contexts and HCI experiences (similar to [3]). Though we do not claim to use the same first-person methods as Bell et al. [5], our decolonial aims in presenting diverse voices are similar: We work in an “*epistemic and methodological space where the personal intersects with the political, historical, and cultural to critique everyday power structures... we strive to imagine a New University characterized by radical hope,*” where this paper imagines and offers an example of HCI academia beyond English hegemony.

2 Researchers’ reflections on writing in english for HCI

As we pondered over our experiences of writing in English, oftentimes thinking multiple languages and working with data that may or may not be in English, several key themes emerged - expectations and experiences of the writing process, challenges in translating culturally nuanced terms - especially user quotes and expressions - and navigating collaborative research when working in multiple languages.

2.1 Experiences of Writing for HCI Research in English

We speak an array of languages – Bengali, Catalan, Finnish, French, Hindi, Persian, Punjabi, Mandarin-Chinese, Marathi, Spanish, Urdu, and English, and have varying levels of experience as researchers, from master’s thesis workers to those with one to two decades of

HCI experience. From our reflections emerge diverse experiences and feelings towards writing in English, such as feeling liberated by the opportunity to be gender-neutral in writing.

Usually, I write in English from the very beginning, otherwise I get entangled between different ways of thinking. Surprisingly, the hardest part is not mastering the words (which I also struggle with) but learning to express oneself within the limitations of academic paper formats. Space tends to be limited, and English style forces the writer to *ir al grano*. Basically, this means to go straight to the key ideas you want to share, without preambles. For me, as a Spanish speaker, this feels like amputating the first part of anything I would say. And I need my intros! They are the context I need to share with whoever is willing to devote some time to read those words. The thing gets worse, as this efficient communication style also permeates academic communication. People are expected to communicate precisely, and concisely, without more words or information that the strictly required or the attention from the others involved in the conversation will drop. Time and words become resources to use efficiently, rather than tools to make sense and build knowledge.

On a few occasions, I have written academic texts in Spanish. Years have gone by since then, and I must say that writing in my mother tongues is on the list of things I want to focus more on in the near future. What became terribly obvious when writing in Spanish after a while of focusing in English was the extent to which sexism/*machismo* was embedded in the language. As writer/speaker you are “forced” to specify the gender of the words (nouns) you use in your speech. I’m aware many would say “*el idioma no es sexista, son las normas y los hablantes los que hacen un uso sexista*”. However, having to specify the gender of each word in a cultural context where sexism in language has become so natural that you really need to make a conscious effort to express yourself in a way that is a bit more inclusive doesn’t make things easy. Thus, for me switching to English and its gender-neutrality felt liberating (at least in that sense). *Summary/ key idea: El problema no es el idioma, es la ideología que circula en torno a ciertas formas de expresarse.*

While the writing process can be strategized, beginning by drafting an outline and filling in each section,

通常我会先写出来文章的大纲，然后当我有一些想法，或者一些观点发现的时候，在每个部分进行填充。文章一开始会非常的混乱，最后一些观点被保留而一些观点被删除 (I usually start by drafting an outline for the article, and as I develop ideas or discover insights, I fill in each section accordingly. Initially, the article is often very disorganized, but eventually, some ideas are retained while others are removed.)

It can still be riddled with complexities, such as for neurodivergent researchers,

As a native English speaker, over the years I have learnt various mechanisms to overcome my neurodivergent writing quirks so few can pick them up. I am not even sure if all my colleagues or peers know that I am neurodivergent, but I have a feeling after this they will. I mask my quirks for many reasons, the stigmatism of not fitting in, the lack of professionalism and the potential impacts on my career. My career that is a whole other story. . .

Writing for me, can vary significantly some days I can write uninhabited and it is clear and concise; while on other days my

writing is discombobulated. On those days, my writing reads perfectly in my head while on paper on the screen there are words missing. However, when I read the same sentence my brain fills in the words, so it reads perfectly to me. When I get others to read it, I believe that they would think I have aphasia. I imagine this in my mind as a mirror reflecting my image but the reality is a bullet-riddled visage. The ways I have found around it is to use speech-to-text writers speaking out my sentences and paragraphs. That or begging my poor partner to read my writing to ensure that I don't sound insane.

I have lived in a number of non-English countries during my career; during which I have attempted to learn a number of other languages. My neurodivergent brain has not enjoyed this process as I have "mastered" English and do not have the same level of expression in the other language and struggle, it makes me reflect on The Chaos poem by Gerard Nolst Trenité on the process of learning English.

Generative AI offers an opportunity to expand the usage of our native languages in academic research and teaching. While instead, it seems to be usurping this opportunity and furthering cultural imperialism to enforce the usage of American English even on us who use British English. When I am reading and encountering generative AI created text, it offers an emotionally devoid text, lacking tone and nuance and reeks of unprofessionalism. The soul of the writer and the effort it takes has therefore been removed and instead it offers bland non-specific bleh! This should not be the case, AI should be used for the advancement of society and not further usurp power for profit.

Many languages employ grammar rules that are different to English adding another layer of complexity to the translation. While Bengali has a rich vocabulary that supports both formal and informal writing, it doesn't use articles such as "a", "an", "the" and follows different rules for the tense of verbs,

Positive: বাংলা ভাষার broad vocabulary সহজ ভাবে translate করতে পারে যে কোনো expression কে English এ. বাংলা ভাষায় formal and informal দুটো expression আছে in writing, which suits the academic style required in research papers. বাংলার descriptive nature and richness in expressions, quality of English writing enhance করতে সাহায্য করে by providing detailed descriptions and comprehensive explanations. Negative: বাংলার ব্যাকরণ English এর থেকে আলাদা. বাংলা Subject-Object-Verb (SOV) order follow করে, আবার English Subject-Verb-Object (SVO) follow করে. এটা awkward sentence structures হয়ে যায় in English if direct translations are attempted.

আবার বাংলাতে article ("a", "an", "the") use নেই as in English, যেটা English এ লেখার সময় error হতে পারে. বাংলায় verb tense গুলো English verb tense এর সাথে যায় না. This can lead to inappropriate verb tense usage, তাহলে clarity and accuracy of the writing affected হতে পারে.

As we reflected on our process of academic writing, we uncovered complex internal and external conflicts that we face that possibly other young and seasoned HCI researchers might face too, as discussed next.

2.2 Reflections Beyond Writing – Identities and Careers in a Flux

Writing for research extends beyond the act of writing itself, encompassing reviewers who bring in certain expectations and specific contextual knowledge, urging us to provide more context and positionality, which is very intimidating for young researchers, who might then question their place in HCI research. While practice makes perfect, reviewing papers also helped us improve our writing process,

Research paper writing is like Lohe ka Chana Chabana. Reviewers ki asim kripa par acceptance / rejection ka manthan hone ke baad research paper ka farman aata hain. The journey of my research paper writing is a krantikari pariwartan. As a beginner when I first started writing my first paper the first fearful thought which came to my mind was "Ghanta Likhogee". Aukat hain kya likhane ki. . . Isiliyea I used to refer to a paper with a renowned publication, fairly high citation. Us jamane main research paper writing had a conventional take with specific jargons and traditional style of writing. The most gambhir samasyay was how good kahanikaar you are in explaining the context. Dhere Dhere waqt ke sath the style has changed. The style of writing has also changed to catchy titles, video abstract submissions with integration of LMM and large numbers of publication channels.

These days writing in English is not the Samasyayi. The gambhir samasyay is still how to narrate the originality and innovation of your work. With increase in conferences, journals, and publication, katu pratispardha has increased. Arthat, aaj ke katuspardha main correct strategy to send the paper to appropriate Journal/Conference is essential. Meri sabse achi learning hain review process main, once you are the reviewer of few Conference/Journal you understand the process better. In sab ke baad bhi I still get my paper rejected and I am still learning and evolving. In short, রিসার্চ পপার লিখন এক অনন্ত প্রক্রিয়া hain.

Yet, writing is an art than can also transform our sense of self and our identity, in some cases creating a yearning for an eloquently expressive past self, leading one to question one's identity as a writer,

Identity change: from being a talented writer (dreaming about earning your living, expressing yourself in beautiful ways, telling exciting, engaging, inspiring, provocative, thought-provoking stories) to being an average (if not bad) writer, managing expressing yourself, but not in an eloquent way. Such a change caused sorrow at some point of time, but you get used to almost anything. I have written my scientific papers all in English, but as a student in Cultural Anthropology, all student assignments were written in Finnish. I'm actually surprised how mature those texts seem. As a student, I had interesting ideas and was able to put those into words in an eloquent way. Partly, this might be due to the language I used, even though I had to translate the ideas in my references to Finnish.

Then, there is the distinction between writing for academia versus writing for, say, software documentation. Are the demands of academic writing impacting the career choices of master's students, and will LLMS mitigate this problem by providing a universally acceptable way of academic, or make it worse?

Allekirjoittaneen akateeminen matka alkoi aikoinaan kotikaupunkini yliopiston tutkinto-ohjelmasta, joka kantoi tuolloin nimeä *English philology*. Juuri armeijasta selvinneenä kloppina olin *insecure about* kaikesta osaamiseeni liittyvästä, mutta yksi asia oli varmaa: englantia minä osasin, ja hyvin osasinkin. Kuten jokunen muukin myöhäinen milleniaali, diginatiivina viihdyin lapsuudessani usein paremmin ruudun ääressä kuin futisnurmella tai pihapeleissä. Englanti *de facto lingua francana* oli *day-to-day* elämässäni alati läsnä, oli sitten kyse YouTube-videoista, keskustelupalstoista tai MMO-peleistä, ja kielen oppiminen tapahtui passiivisesti osmoosin kautta. Lukioaikoina englanti oli jo sillä tasolla, että kirjoitin ylioppilaskokeiden ainoan laudaturini ilman sen kummempia ponnisteluja. Olin siis valmis kohtaamaan akateemisen maailman haasteet, aseinani *reasonably* hyvä kielipää ja isohko sanavarasto.

Tai niin kuvittelin. Yhdysvaltalaisprofessorin vetämällä akateemisen viestinnän kursilla totuus iski vasten kasvoja: enhän minä englantia osannut, tai ainakin siltä se tuntui: tiedemaailman vaatimustaso oli kaukana siitä, mihin olin tottunut. No, laadukkaan kurssin päätteeksi olin päässyt kohtuullisen hyvin jyvälle akateemisesta englannista, ja ne taidot kannoin mukana vaihdettuani alaa parin vuoden päästä vaihdettuani pääainetta *computer science* puolelle. Suomenkielisessä kandidaatinohjelmassa huomasin tuskailevani lähes päinvastaisen ongelman kanssa: teknistä terministöä on nihkeä kääntää englannista suomeksi, ja usein kirjoitukseksi lähestyivätkin tämän tekstin kaltaista kömpelöä *finenglishiä*. Päädyin usein kysymään äidinkieltäni puhuvilta vastuuolettajilta, voinko suorittaa essee tehtävät englanniksi, enkä ollut ainoa joka niin teki.

Vuosien varrella pistin merkille, että harva opiskelutovereistani edes harkitsi akateemista uraa realistisena uravaihtoehtona. Toki ala on muutenkin *industry*-voittoinen, mutta en voi olla miettimättä, onko lingvistikilla tai käännöksellisillä haasteilla suuntaan tai toiseen ollut vaikutusta siihen, miten he akateemiseen kirjoittamiseen suhtautuvat. Kenties vauhdilla kehittyvät *Large Language Modelit* toimivat tulevaisuudessa myös akateemisen viestinnän universaalina tulkkina eli ”Baabelin kalana”, Douglas Adamsin romaania *Linnunradan käsikirja liftareille* lainaten. Baabelin kala oli korvakäytävään tunkeutuva loinen, joka käytti ravinnoksen ihmisten aivot toiminnasta syntyvää energiaa, ja vastapainoksi sai isäntänsä ymmärtämään kaikkia maailman kieliä. Lienee osaltaan myös *AI literacy*yn keskittyvien HCI-tutkijoiden vastuulla varmistaa, että tulevaisuuden *Baabelin kielimallit* edesauttavat ja helpottavaa viestintää, eivätkä nakerra loisen lailla itsenäistä ajattelua.

Summary: As a young/aspiring researcher, I wrote more from a student’s perspective, recounting my own experiences as someone who completed a degree in computer science after switching from an English major. I note the difference between having a ‘good’ proficiency in English as a second language and writing it at an academic level. I ponder if linguistic limitations or inconveniences have affected the popularity of academia as a career option among my peers. I conclude the text with a humorous yet clumsy reference to the Douglas Adams’s comedic science fiction novel *Hitchhiker’s Guide to the Galaxy* [2], speculating whether LLMs could become a universal solution to language barriers, briefly mentioning the role of HCI AI literacy research in mitigating the risks associated with such a scenario.

While many things have changed across the last few decades, including the writing style and expectations (submitting videos, using LLMs); being successful in writing for research is akin to being a brilliant storyteller. Yet, this is intimidating - to strive to be a compelling storytelling in our second, third, or fourth language! No wonder this gives rise to conflicts in our identity as a writer and as an academic. Will CHI ever know how smart, compelling, and brilliant we are as storytellers in our native languages?

2.3 The Challenges of Translating Culturally Nuanced Expressions and Concepts

Considering our diverse research experiences, we highlight the complexity of translating culturally nuanced terms to English and the difficulty in conveying the richness of our thoughts, context of work, and users’ experiences. For example, it is extremely challenging to translate poetic responses from users,

Images(意象) are beyond translation 意象超越表面意义, 隐含更深层次的象征意义, 通常表达难以直接描述的思想, 感受和概念的综合体 (Imagery transcends surface meaning, embodying deeper symbolic significance. It is often a synthesis of thoughts, feelings, and concepts that are difficult to express directly). In a study, I asked participants which of the two different modes of expression provided by Emotion AI—animation or text—made them feel more comfortable. The participant expressed in Mandarin-Chinese, “我认为是动画, 因为情感是绵延, 连续的, 像河流一样, 像水一样, 你懂吧。”(I think it’s animation because emotions are continuous and flowing, like a river, like water—you know what I mean.) What they meant is... 水在中国文化中拥有非常多的意象。例如知名的例子, 老子(中国道教代表人物之一)说过:“上善若水, 水善利万物而不争, 处众人之所恶, 故几于道。”“水不仅仅代表仁慈, 也代表着一种中国文化中的智慧。因此, 用户用水做比喻的时候潜移默化带入了他对情感细微的理解和解读, 即柔和, 不明确的表达, 中庸之道。然而这种细微的感受难以用英文描述, 尽管不是表达的主体, 但其中暗藏的需求确实非常关键。在实际撰写文章的时候, 我首先直接翻译了用户的表达, 然而我无法在文章中详细解释以上的文化背景和我认为的参与者可能暗藏的需求和隐喻。因此我只能摘取最明显和直观的分析。即, 参与者认为情感是连续的体验, 动画不断变化的表达更符合他对情感的感受。Water holds a rich array of imagery in Chinese culture. A well-known example is Laozi (one of the key figures in Chinese Taoism), who said 上善若水, 水善利万物而不争, 处众人之所恶, 故几于道。 (“The highest good is like water. Water benefits all things and does not compete. It resides in places that others disdain; thus, it is close to the Way”). Water not only symbolizes compassion but also embodies a unique wisdom in Chinese culture. When the participant used water as a metaphor, they subconsciously infused their nuanced understanding and interpretation of emotions—emphasizing softness, ambiguity, and the philosophy of balance or moderation. However, such delicate feelings are difficult to fully articulate in English. Although not the primary focus of their expression, the underlying nuances reflect an important perspective. When drafting my article, I began by directly translating the participant’s response. However, I was

unable to elaborate on the cultural context or the implicit needs and metaphors I believed the participant might have conveyed. As a result, I focused on the most apparent and straightforward analysis: the participant viewed emotions as a continuous experience, and the ever-changing nature of animation aligns more closely with their perception of emotions.

Or expressing users' frustrations,

"Mulla kai nyt on ihan vitun tekevä mitä ihmiset tekkee, niikö kattoo tai ei kato paljo. Jokainen kattoo sen verran ku kattoo aiheel-liseksi kattoo." In discussing in Finnish with research participants, doing discourse oriented research - so much is lost, considering nuances, meanings, dialects. The above citation produces many insights for native Finnish language speakers, showing the dialect (representing a geographic area in Finland), emphasis with the use of the most powerful curse word in Finnish, producing a stance towards media consumption as well as research, showing being a (woman) media consumer and research participant.

It is also difficult to do justice to users' complex emotional experiences when translating to English. Even with a detailed explanation of their cultural context and background, the gravity of their situation might not come through,

I once conducted research with pregnant women in a rural area two hours from Lahore, near the Indian border. I found it extremely challenging to convey the context and nuances of the qualitative data in our research paper. Two critical aspects of the interviews stood out. First, the contextual dynamics: the interviews were frequently interrupted by the mother-in-law and husband, significantly influencing the participants' responses. The participants had to adjust their tone, choice of words, and non-verbal cues, often giving responses with dual meanings to navigate the presence of others in the room. This added a layer of complexity to interpreting their true thoughts and feelings. Second, their linguistic and emotional diversity: the conversations were not confined to a single language but were a blend of Urdu, Punjabi, and less common words, even unfamiliar to many Punjabi speakers. This linguistic mixture and the participants' fluctuating tones and emotions reflected their multifaceted experiences and challenges during pregnancy.

مجھے لگتا ہے کہ میں نے بچہ پیدا کر کے کوئی بہت بڑا گناہ کر لیا ہے۔
میری زندگی وچ پہلے وی سکون نہیں سی تے بن تے بالکل مک گیا اے۔
طعنے سن سن کے کہ کوئی وکھری گل نہیں بوئی، اسی تے دس دس پیدا کیتے
نے، دباڑی نئیں چھڈنی، تے پتا نئیں بور کی کی۔
سکون تو صرف قبر میں ہے۔ - لگتا ہے سکون کدے نہیں آئے گا

"I feel like by getting pregnant, I've committed a grave sin. There was no peace in my life before, and now it's completely gone. Listening to constant taunts like, 'this is nothing special, we've had ten children ourselves, don't skip your daily work,' and so much more. It feels like peace will never come. peace can only be found in the grave."

The word "سکون" (*sakoon*) carries layers of meaning in Urdu that are difficult to translate into English. In the context I have described, its repeated use reflects not just a longing for "peace" but also a plea for basic dignity, relief, or the right to exist without undue burden or oppression. This nuanced understanding often gets lost in translation. For example, in one sentence: "مجھے بس تھوڑا سا سکون چاہیے". Translating it as "I just want a little peace" misses the cultural and emotional weight. Here, "سکون" conveys a basic

human need for respite, free from constant struggle or stress, not necessarily tranquility in a serene or idyllic sense. In qualitative analysis, such linguistic richness underscores the importance of leaving certain key terms untranslated, with annotations explaining their context and connotations.

Further, complex concepts in one language are even more difficult to translate to another, our struggle is then experienced in multiple languages,

One word I always struggle with is *machismo* and *patriarcado*. In English these words would translate as "sexism" and "patriarchy". On the first one (*machismo*), I never felt that sexism gets truly the point of what I want to say when the word machista comes to my mind. Same happens when one notices *las costuras de un sistema patriarcal*, how should I translate that in plain language? It is hard enough to identify and deconstruct these oppressions to then feel stuck because I can't find the words. Or when I find them, the translation feels awkward. Of course, it might be me that I don't master English well enough. But it might be also that we still face a long way to be able to talk, question and find alternatives to these systems in our everyday words. I hope it's the first case.

While there are difficulties in translating expressions, concepts, and terms to English from other languages, these challenges are exacerbated when there are word or page limits to the paper, as explanations of the contexts and terms, take away space from other parts of the paper. Even if the length is not fixed, the extra text can make the reading cumbersome. This dual penalty in writing in English for research unfairly impacts younger researchers,

میرا experience یہ ہے کہ researchers جنکی native language English نہیں ہوتی، وہ زیادہ تر اپنی research بھی اپنی community کے ساتھ کرتے ہیں، تو جب paper English میں لکھتے ہیں، تو انکو double penalty لگتی ہے۔ پہلے تو، translation میں کافی time and effort لگتا ہے، جب data analysis ہوتا ہے۔ پھر جو quotes paper میں جاتے ہیں، انکو describe اور contextualise کرنا پڑتا ہے، کیونکہ quotes بیना context sense نہیں بناتے۔ پھر use context کو بھی describe کرنا پڑتا ہے۔ Most conferences میں word یا page limit ہوتی ہے، تو آپکو انہی limits میں extra context دینا پڑتا ہے، which takes space۔ پھر reviewer comments دیتے ہیں کہ اس paper کو native English speaker سے proofread کرنا پڑے، جس سے پैसे لگتے ہیں۔ تو non-native English researchers، جس میں سے میں کافی 2 سے بھی زیادہ languages بول سکتے ہیں، spend a lot more time, effort, and money paper لکھنے میں۔ Young researchers کے لیے بہت expensive ہوجاتا ہے، اور اس میں تو conference travel اور registration شامل نہیں ہے۔

Summary – Researchers who are not native-English speakers bear a double penalty when writing for research in English. Since, first, they probably conduct their research in their native language, so there is a cost (time, effort, money) in translating materials to English for analysis and writing. Second, it can take a lot of space to provide context, not only of the work, but the findings and quotes, taking away space from other sections of the paper. These costs associated with translation unfairly impact young researchers who have limited funds and must consider also the costs of conference travel and publishing.

Overall, translation to English leads to a loss of nuanced meaning in qualitative findings. Furthermore, the burden of explanation of those nuances and contexts, which are still lossy, are expensive

(time, effort, money) and intimidating, impacting young researchers unfairly (as also reflected on in section 2.2).

2.4 Collaborating in Multilingual Environments – Ping-Ponging from One Language to Another

In our reflections, we contemplated on the challenges of multilingual working environments and the hurdles in finding common vocabularies and following a dominant working language,

Writing together is challenging, especially when none of the writers is using their native language. I find it so *difícil* because, for me, writing is not about typing words to express an idea, but it's about making sense. *Per a mí, escriure és una manera de donar forma al pensament, així com de trobar els límits dels meus raonaments.* Thus, writing with others becomes “thinking with others”, with the added difficulty that the meaning behind certain words might be affected not only by language, but also by the field of knowledge and the conceptual lens each one is using. *En algunos casos, la escritura colaborativa se vuelve una experiencia surrealista. Tras un aparente acuerdo sobre las palabras y las frases elegidas, pueden existir sentidos completamente distintos y, a veces, hasta opuestos.* How to know *de qué estamos hablando si ni siquiera puedo estar segura de entender cómo piensa el/la otro?*

Or translating technical concepts in English for a non-English audience for fieldwork, and translating from non-English to English for reporting the findings, stuck in a loop of translations,

Translating innovative concepts and terms from English to Persian, especially in contexts like digital fabrication and making, presents several challenges. These challenges often arise due to linguistic, cultural, and conceptual gaps between the two languages. Many terms in digital fabrication (e.g., makerspace, fab lab, tinkering) are relatively new and lack direct Persian equivalents. Translators often need to either create new terms or adapt existing ones. Some terms are left untranslated or phonetically adapted, such as “printer-e se-bo'di” for ‘3D printer’. While practical, this approach risks alienating those unfamiliar with the English root.

On the other hand, for translating from Persian to English, many Persian terms carry layers of cultural and emotional resonance that are difficult to convey in English. For example, terms like “honar-e dast” (with literal meaning of “the art of hands”) not only describe handmade crafts but also evoke a sense of tradition, pride, and cultural identity. Translating it as “handmade art” or “craft” simplifies its meaning and loses this cultural depth. Moreover, Persian often uses metaphorical or poetic language to describe concepts, which can be hard to replicate in English without sounding overly flowery or losing the original intent. For instance, the phrase “bazi-e dastan” (with literal meaning of “play of hands”) beautifully conveys both creativity and physical engagement but translating it directly as “tinkering” fails to capture its elegance and dual meaning. Also, when translating terms with historical significance, English translations often strip away the rich cultural and historical context embedded in the Persian term. For example, “kargah” (with the literal translation of “workshop”) in Persian implies a space not only for making but also for learning, mentorship, and intergenerational knowledge transfer, which may not be fully captured by the English equivalent. These challenges underscore the complexities

of translating not just words, but entire systems of thought and culture. While Persian terms often emphasize holistic, emotional, and community-oriented aspects, English may lean toward clarity, precision, and universality.

Concepts that are difficult to define and explain in English, such as trust, trustworthy, and trustworthiness of information, become increasingly complex to translate to, say, Urdu. While the word for trust can be found in Urdu (“bharosa”), its contextual use in a study does not necessarily have simple translation in English. Can use of only technical English terms diminish our ability to discuss the same concepts in our native language? Who are we then, if our proficiency in one language negatively impacts our proficiency in another like a zero-sum game,

کا کیا تعلق معلومات کی aesthetics میری تحقیق تھی کہ یہ دریافت کیا جائے کہ قابل اعتماد ہونے سے ہے۔ اس پر تحقیق کرنے کے لیے میں نے دستاویزات بنائیں جن میں ایک ہی معلومات تھیں لیکن ایک سیٹ کمپیوٹر پر چھپا ہوا تھا، اور دوسرا ہاتھ سے لکھا ہوا۔ میں نے یہ سیٹ لوگوں کو دکھایا اور ان سے ریٹ کروایا کہ کون سی دستاویز زیادہ قابل اعتماد ہے۔ اس میں سے ایک انٹرویو میں، ایک شرکت کنندہ، جو کہ اردو بولتے ہیں، اپنے انٹرویو میں قابل اعتماد ہونے کے لیے لفظ استعمال - بھروسہ اور اعتماد دو اردو کے لفظ ہیں جن کا تقریبی ترجمہ ”قابل بھروسہ“ کیا ہے، لیکن دونوں میں باریک فرق ہیں جو کہ صرف ایک سادہ ”trust“ انگریزی میں ترجمے سے ظاہر نہیں کیے جا سکتے۔ اس سے مجھے احساس ہوا کہ قابل اعتماد سے نہیں ہے، اس میں ایک ذاتی اور جذباتی پہلو ”trust“ ہونے کا تعلق صرف بھی ہے جو کہ منطقی حصے سے الگ ہے۔ تحقیق میں شامل شخص نے کوشش کی کہ وہ وضاحت کر سکے کہ یہ کیسے قابل اعتماد ہونے سے متعلق ہے، لیکن پھر صرف قابل اعتماد اور بھروسے کے قابل ہونے کے بارے میں ”قابل بھروسہ“ بھی نہیں ہے، جس کا ترجمہ کرنے میں مجھے اپنی تحقیق کے لیے مشکل پیش آئی۔ اس کی وجہ سے مجھے یہ بھی احساس ہوا کہ میں خود اپنی تحقیق کے بارے میں اپنی مادری زبان میں سوچنے میں محدود ہوں۔ میں اپنی خود کی سوچ کے بارے میں ایک پورا میری شناخت کا حصہ جو میں نظر انداز کرتا ہوں۔ اور بھی دلچسپ بات ہے کہ اردو زبان مجھے الفاظ کی زیادہ اظہار کی اجازت دیتی ہے لیکن اس اظہار کو میں نے عرصے سے استعمال نہیں کیا کیونکہ میری ساری تحقیق کا اظہار انگریزی زبان میں انگریزی سامعین کے لیے انگریزی تناظر میں ہوتا ہے۔ یہاں تک کہ جب میں پاکستان میں اپنا کام لکھ یا پیش کر رہا ہوتا ہوں، میرا پہلا طریقہ اظہار، زبانی اور تحریری دونوں، انگریزی میں ہوتا ہے۔ یہ افسوسناک ہے، لیکن یہ میری متنازعہ حقیقت ہے۔

Such challenges are experienced by everyone, not only non-native English speakers,

I am a native English speaker, so I don't have too much to add. One time I was reviewing a paper where they were studying a tangible design in the context of gift-giving around Christmas in a Northwest global context. I asked them to very briefly explain Christmas as a holiday and the accompanying gift-giving tradition. I am not sure this suggestion was taken seriously; the authors felt comfortable assuming that “everyone” already knows this.

One time I was submitting a paper in collaboration with international students. One of the design ideas in the paper was situated around Diwali. The reviewers asked us to explain Diwali. Fortunately, we were able to do so very concisely in just a sentence, but it brought to mind the cultural assumptions embedded into our scholarship, and how the need to explain is unequally imposed. I think explaining is good, I don't mind having to explain, but everyone should have to explain.

HCI researchers are working tirelessly towards raising the voices of under-represented and marginalised user groups across the world, navigating cross-cultural communications and research. As technical vocabularies find their way into a multitude of languages,

and languages evolve to fit the needs of our current experiences, could there be spaces that add to, rather than subtract from, how we think and discuss our ideas and experiences?

2.5 Authors' Positionalities

Sumita Sharma is an Indian living and working in Finland with almost 12 years of research experience working with neurodiverse and neurotypical children in India and Finland, and more recently with neurotypical children in Japan and the USA on critical AI literacy and ethical technology futures.

Behnaz Norouzi is a Persian living and working in Finland with almost 7 years of research experience in the field of Child-Computer Interaction and more specifically, shaping children's digital fabrication experiences in Fab Labs and understanding children as technology protagonists.

Edward White is a native English speaking South African, who has lived in Finland for the past 6 years. Previously he lived in Sweden, where he spent 3 years completing his PhD. He has worked in various roles in academia for 20 years. His research primarily focuses on how technologies affect work-family conflict (work-life balance).

Raised bilingual, Eva Durall Gazulla, has been using and mixing Spanish and Catalan as a child. English became the main work language as she started working in academia, more than ten years ago. With a background in new media, design and pedagogy, she moved to Finland to conduct her doctoral studies and continued her post-doctoral career also in Finnish universities. Her current research focuses on critical data literacy and education for democracy.

Mohsin Yousufi is a Pakistani living in the U.S. for the last 4 years for his doctoral studies researching how to design inclusive and effective civic engagement tools for resource-constrained communities. He has been speaking English and Urdu since he was a kid, with a special emphasis on English throughout his K-12 education.

Netta Iivari is a Finnish speaking Finn living in Finland. She lived in the US for 6 months during her teenage years. Ever since, she has considered her English skills quite good. She has a master's degree in Cultural Anthropology, within which all studies were carried out in Finnish. When she started to work as a research assistant in HCI at the university, she had to change the language to English. She has always been interested in relations between humans and technology, starting from exploring young women's television discourses, moving on understanding and strengthening people's participation in shaping and making their digital futures. For more than 15 years, she has explored empowerment of children through design and digital technology.

Noura Howell is a cis white woman from middle class upbringing in the US South, from a multicultural and multi-religion family.

Pauli Klemettilä is a Finnish graduate student of computer science and an aspiring researcher, with his first paper as a second author being published in the main event of CHI 2025. A late millennial and digital native, he has been learning English through osmosis from a young age; and completed one year of English language studies in his university before switching majors to technology.

Suleman Shahid is a Pakistani living and working in Lahore, Pakistan. Suleman is deeply passionate about the city's rich heritage, vibrant culture, and evolving art scene. With over 15 years of experience, he specializes in designing interactive and assistive technologies that enhance learning and well-being for children and the elderly. His work bridges innovation and inclusivity, creating meaningful digital experiences for diverse communities.

Sayan Sarcar is an Indian living and working in the United Kingdom with more than 15 years of research experience in the field of Human-Computer Interaction and Accessibility and Assistive Technology. In addition to English, he is fluent in both Bengali and Hindi.

Xingyu Li is Chinese and was raised in China, with Mandarin as the sole language of her education. Although she has studied English for over ten years, she rarely used it in daily life. English became her primary working language when she entered academia during her undergraduate studies. Later, she will complete her master's and doctoral degrees in the United States.

Wricha Mishra is an Indian who is proficient in several Indian languages, including Hindi and Bengali, in addition to English. Her research focuses on areas such as Persuasive Design, Human Factors, and Conversational Interfaces.

3 GOING FORWARD

With this paper, we start a conversation on how CHI can be linguistically diverse and inclusive to neurotypical and neurodiverse non-native- and native-English researchers. While we presented a lot of challenges in writing in English for CHI, this comes from a place of love – a love for writing and bringing users' experience to a larger community and the joy of sharing our ideas and insights. To celebrate the rich social, cultural, linguistic, regional diversity of the CHI community, there are many ways forward. First and foremost, having flexible word limits for papers, like CHI does already, provides authors with space to discuss the context of their work and describe culturally nuanced user insights without having to take away from other parts of the paper. While non-native English researchers are happy to provide this context – to situate their work and findings. Wouldn't it be wonderful if providing such context is required in all papers, since not everyone is familiar with English-speaking cultural and geographical contexts. Why assume that the reviewer, who could be from anywhere in the world, is familiar with certain contexts? This could be extended to presenting author positionality in all qualitative and mixed-method research, which is also a growing trend. However, as the living-document on reviewing for CHI discusses [9], in some contexts authors' might intentionally conceal their positionality or certain identities to avoid being targeted or harmed, therefore, while this solves some issues, it may give rise to others. There is no one solution fits all when it comes to strategies for linguistic inclusion and diversity in CHI.

Seasoned researchers tend to think in academic English or have trained themselves to think in a specific way but are we slowly losing our rich vocabularies in other languages and contexts? Are all heading towards speaking one type of academic English, especially with content from LLMs being embedded in research? We wholeheartedly support CHI's policies on use of LLMs, which support diversity and inclusion. Furthermore, research has started to

show that such tools benefit those from marginalised, minority backgrounds the most [12]. But could we imagine newer ways of writing with these new tools without losing out on the rich and diverse linguistic culture of HCI research and researchers? Could there be multilingual spaces that are open to all – in papers, at conferences? Could authors write in their native languages and paper chairs and associate chairs recruit reviewers with domain expertise and fluency in the languages of the papers? Or could we level the playing field by using an alternative language (such as, Esperanto) which will be new for everyone? Again, we might not agree on only one or the other.

Lastly, writing in English unfairly impacts young researchers as they are new to academic writing, plus they might be conducting research in other languages. Translating requires either some funding, which they might not have, or a lot of manual effort and time – time and effort that is taken away from their research, field work, and writing. They may also be unfairly flagged by GPT detectors, shown to be biased against non-native English writers [11][12]. These problems might take a minute to unpack and resolve, to guide young researchers in ways that have a positive impact on their careers. For now, we as reviewers can be more appreciative of the efforts (and burden) of translations and writing in a non-native language. Furthermore, could experienced researchers mentor younger ones, and those who require support for writing in English, as they write their first paper for CHI?

Considering inclusion and diversity of languages and expressions at CHI, an academic community, also aligns with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goal (UN SDG) of Reduced Inequalities (SDG #10), in this case, within academic discourse, creating impacts beyond CHI and the HCI community.

The limitations of this work include the lack of a systematic analysis of case studies from both the authors' and others' successful and unsuccessful paper submissions and reviews, as well as the absence of concrete proposed solutions. Moving forward, we intend to build on this work by addressing these limitations through the analysis of specific paper reviews and case studies that were affected by writing-related challenges. Furthermore, we will invite non-native English researchers from various fields, including STEM, medicine, arts, and humanities, to explore whether they face similar challenges when publishing in English and to examine differences in experiences between formal and informal writing.

While this paper presents a few possible solutions—such as more flexible review guidelines to accommodate different writing styles and qualities and ensuring that papers are not penalized for language issues that can be resolved through proofreading or AI tools—it does not aim to provide final solutions. Rather, our goal is to raise thought-provoking questions about linguistic inclusion and diversity at CHI and to begin a collective journey, as a community, toward developing diverse strategies and solutions.

At the conference, a summary of the work will be first presented in English, and then in multiple languages including Finnish, Hindi, Spanish, and Urdu, and more depending on the authors who are available to present and/or record a video. In this way, the CHI community will not only get a chance to read and see multiple languages, but also hear the authors verbally emote in their native languages. Afterall, some of us are brilliant storytellers!

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A APPENDICES

A.1 Writing prompt sent to co-authors via email

We are planning a paper that captures the diversity of languages that researchers bring to HCI – which must be simplified and translated to English for papers for a wider audience. In these translations to English – the richness of our thoughts, insights, user quotes, etc are sometimes lost.

Wouldn't it be nice if we could write about our research the way we think about it in our heads or unpack the nuances of our context of work and what users said, without having to worry about paper length and number of words? Or use terms and phrases as is

colloquially common in our native languages or in local variations of *Englishes*? What would diversity of expression and languages in HCI research papers look like? What if the English audience is the one that translates the text, versus the other way?

If these thoughts and questions resonate with you, please join Noura and I in our alt.CHI paper, tentatively titled - “Lost in translation: Researchers’ reflections on writing in English for CHI”

For this paper, we invite you to submit a 250-350 words piece of writing in any language, a local variation of English, or a mix of languages (e.g., Hindi + English = Hinglish), (however you would think when) answering one or more of the following questions:

Do you have a research experience / interaction with a user / local field experience that you would like to share with the HCI community in your native language? Something might not really

translate well in English or is just nice to have in your native language. Can be something nice, though-provoking, or maybe something not so nice.

What is your process for writing a research paper? Have you written research papers in your first language – how was that experience? What do you think works well or doesn’t when writing research papers in English? Are there terms / insights / user quotes that you used / wanted to use in a paper that did not translate well in English – what were those terms? How did you translate them? What was still missing?

Are there terms / insights / user quotes that you used / wanted to use in a paper that did not translate well in English – what were those terms? How did you translate them? What was still missing?